11-Year-Old Bodhana Makes Chess History

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Imagine becoming one of the best chess players in the world before you finish middle school! That is true for Bodhana Sivanandan, an 11-year-old from northwest London, England. On September 26, 2026, she became the youngest person ever to earn the Woman **Grandmaster** title. The old record was held by Kateryna Lagno, who was 12 in 2002. To earn this high honor, a player must reach a **rating** of at least 2,300 points and meet special rules in three qualifying **tournaments**, called **norms**. Bodhana found chess in 2020, when she was five, after finding a chessboard in a bag of toys and books. At age seven, she won all 24 of her games at the European Schools Championship. At age 10, she beat **Grandmaster** Peter Wells. In August 2026, she became the youngest-ever British women's chess champion. The next month, at the 46th Chess **Olympiad** in Samarkand, she won six games, drew four, and lost one, earning her final norm. She now hopes to earn the **Grandmaster** title, which is open to players of any gender.

Word Treasure

Grandmaster -- A very high title given to the strongest chess players.
rating -- A number that shows how strong a chess player is.
norms -- Special results a player must earn in strong tournaments to get a title.
tournaments -- Organized contests where many players compete against each other.
Olympiad -- A large team contest where players represent their countries.

Background you need

Chess is a board game where two players move pieces on a board to try to trap the other player's king.

Players can earn special chess titles by playing very well in strong tournaments and reaching a high rating.

The Chess Olympiad is a large team chess event where players represent their countries.

Break it down

WHO: Bodhana Sivanandan, an 11-year-old from northwest London, England
WHAT: She became the youngest person ever to earn the Woman Grandmaster title
WHERE: Samarkand, at the 46th Chess Olympiad, where she earned her final norm
WHY: She reached a rating of at least 2,300 points and met the special rules in three qualifying tournaments

Why it matters

It shows kids that starting small and practicing can lead to big achievements, even before finishing middle school.

Test what you remember

1. How old is Bodhana Sivanandan?

- (A) 12 years old
- (B) 11 years old
- (C) 7 years old
- (D) 10 years old

2. What title did Bodhana become the youngest person ever to earn?

- (A) Grandmaster
- (B) The Woman Grandmaster title
- (C) British women's chess champion
- (D) European Schools champion

3. What rating must a player reach to earn this high honor?

- (A) 2,000 points
- (B) 500 points
- (C) 1,000 points
- (D) At least 2,300 points

4. How did Bodhana first find chess?

- (A) By finding a chessboard in a bag of toys and books
- (B) At a chess club
- (C) In a lesson with a coach
- (D) From a teacher at school

5. Whom did Bodhana beat when she was 10?

- (A) Grandmaster Peter Wells
- (B) The British women's champion
- (C) Kateryna Lagno
- (D) A player at the European Schools Championship

6. Where was the 46th Chess Olympiad where Bodhana earned her final norm?

- (A) London
- (B) Samarkand
- (C) Berlin
- (D) Paris

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):